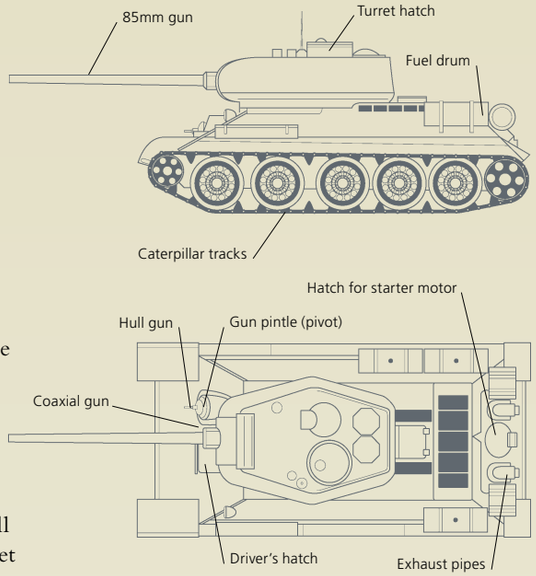
T-34 TANK

The Soviet T-34 is considered by many experts to be the best-designed tank of World War II. Although by the end of the war there were German tanks that outclassed it in firepower and armour, they were heavy, sophisticated machines that could not be produced in such quantities as the relatively straightforward T-34, and never achieved the same ease of operation. Almost 40,000 T-34s were built in the course of the war.

The T-34 was designed by Soviet engineer Mikhail Koshkin, using a suspension developed by the American inventor J Walter Christie. Entering production in summer 1940, the T-34 initially mounted a 76mm main gun – hence the designation T-34/76. It had a crew of four, with the tank commander doubling as the main gunner. The top speed of 51kph (32mph) was impressive for an armoured vehicle, while its relatively light weight and wide tracks were excellent for travelling cross-country over mud and snow. In combat, the high-velocity gun proved effective at armour penetration, and the T-34's own sloped armour, at around 100mm (4in) thick, offered good protection.

The T-34 was definitely not a glamorous vehicle, but it was hardy, easy to repair, and ideally suited to mass production. In 1944 the up-gunned T-34/85 came into service. As well as mounting an 85mm main gun, it had a turret with space for three men, allowing the functions of gunner and commander to be separated. In this version, the T-34 remained in service with some armies into the 1990s.



Russian T-34/85
The T-34/85 had a different profile to its predecessor, the T-34/76. Its turret was flatter, making it a more difficult target, and its main gun was longer.



> THE T-34 WAS THE BEST EXAMPLE OF AN OFFENSIVE WEAPON IN WORLD WAR II ... WE HAD NOTHING COMPARABLE.
>
> **FRIEDRICH VON MELLENTHIN**, GERMAN GENERAL

Gunner in action
The gunner here operates the elevation control on the main gun; the traverse wheel is to his left. He was also responsible for firing the coaxial machine-gun alongside the main gun.



Repair kit
A very basic set of tools was kept inside the tank to meet the need for running repairs.



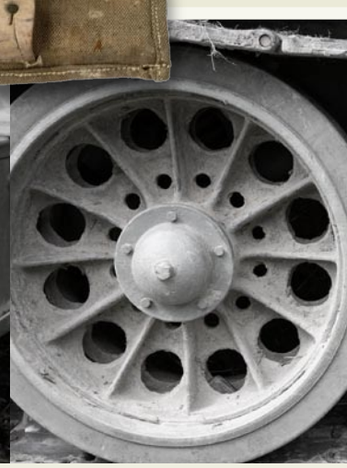
Hull gun
The lower machine-gun was mounted on a pintle that gave it a traverse denied to the static, coaxial gun above it. The gunner sighted through a hole above the barrel.



Driver's hatch
The driver could climb into his seat through a small hatch at the front of the hull. The tank was usually driven with the hatch open to give the driver a better view.



Towing rope
This metal eye was at the end of a wire hawser (large rope) running along the side of the tank. It was used for tasks such as hauling disabled vehicles from the battlefield.



Steel wheel
An all-steel wheel and metal track made the T-34 a noisy vehicle, but its suspension gave it good speed.